

RICHARD J. EVANS

The Coming of the Third Reich



PENGUIN BOOKS

THE BEER-HALL PUTSCH

I

At the end of the First World War, General Erich Ludendorff, Germany's military dictator for the last two years or so of the conflict, thought it prudent to remove himself from the political scene for a while. Dismissed from office on 25 October 1918 after a bitter row with the newly appointed last, liberal government of the Kaiser, he lingered on for a while in Berlin, then, donning dark glasses and false whiskers, he slipped across the Baltic to Sweden to sit out the Revolution. By February 1919 he evidently thought the worst was over and returned to Germany. Such was the prestige he had gained in the war that he quickly became the figurehead of the radical right. A Pan-German annexationist in 1914-18, and a rabid opponent of the Peace Settlement, he immediately began conspiring to overthrow the new Republican order. Gathering a group of his former aides around him, he lent his support to the short-lived putsch mounted against the government in Berlin by Wolfgang Kapp and the Free Corps in March 1920, and when this failed, left for the more congenial atmosphere of Munich. Here he soon came into contact with the ultra-nationalist circle that had by now gathered round the previously unknown figure of Adolf Hitler.³⁶

By the time the two eventually met, Hitler had acquired the first members of the devoted band of enthusiasts who would play a key role in one capacity or another in the growth of the Nazi Party and the building of the Third Reich. Most devoted of all was the student Rudolf Hess, a pupil of the geopolitical theorist Karl Haushofer at Munich University. The son of an authoritarian businessman who had refused to allow him to study before the war, Hess seemed to be looking for a strong leader to whom he could bind himself unconditionally. Like a number of subsequently prominent Nazis, he came from outside the German Reich: Hess was born in Alexandria in 1894. Service in the war, which he ended as an Air Force lieutenant, gave him one kind of authority to obey, study with Haushofer another. Neither gave him what he really wanted, any more than did the Free Corps or the Thule Society, of which Hess was also a member. It was

eventually provided by Hitler, whom he met in 1920. Antisemitism was a shared passion: Hess denounced the ‘pack of Jews’ who he thought had betrayed Germany in 1918, and even before he met Hitler he led expeditions to working-class districts of Munich to slip thousands of antisemitic leaflets under the front doors of workers’ flats.³⁷ Henceforth, Hess directed all the force of his hero-worship towards Hitler. Naive, idealistic, without personal ambition or greed, and, according to Haushofer, not very bright, Hess had an inclination to believe in irrational and mystical doctrines such as astrology; his dog-like devotion to Hitler was almost religious in its fervour; he regarded Hitler as a kind of Messiah. From now on, he would be Hitler’s silent, passive slave, drinking in his master’s words at the regular coffee round in the Café Heck, and gradually taking much of the burden of the routine work Hitler so hated off his shoulders. In addition, he introduced Hitler to an elaborate version of the common Pan-German theory of ‘living-space’, *Lebensraum*, with which Haushofer justified German claims to conquer Eastern Europe, and which the novelist Hans Grimm popularized with his best-seller *Race without Space (Volk ohne Raum)* in 1926.³⁸

Useful to Hitler in another way was the failed racist poet and dramatist Dietrich Eckart, a former medical student. Eckart was already active in far-right circles in December 1918, when he started publishing a political weekly, *In Plain German (Auf gut deutsch)*, with backing from a number of Bavarian businessmen and also the political fund of the army. Eckart blamed his failure to get his plays performed on what he believed to be the Jewish domination of culture. He was in personal contact with other racists and ‘Aryan’ supremacists like Houston Stewart Chamberlain, whose work he did much to popularize. Like many antisemites, he defined as ‘Jewish’ anyone who was ‘subversive’ or ‘materialistic’, including, among others (in his view), Lenin and Kaiser Wilhelm II. Well connected and well off, Eckart, like Hess, was a member of the Thule Society and raised the funds from his friends, and from the army, for the Nazi Party to buy the Society’s ailing newspaper, the *Racial Observer (Völkischer Beobachter)*, in December 1920. He became editor himself, bringing much-needed journalistic experience to its twice-weekly editions and expanding it into a daily early in 1923. Eventually, however, his relative independence, and his rather patronizing attitude towards Hitler, led to a cooling of relations

between the two men, and he was dismissed as editor of the paper in March 1923, dying later in the year.^{[39](#)}

Two associates he brought into the Party from the Thule Society served Hitler more reliably, however, and a good deal longer. The first of these was the Baltic-German architect Alfred Rosenberg. Another leading Nazi from beyond the Reich, he was born in Reval, Estonia, in 1893. He fled the Russian Revolution, conceiving an intense hatred for Bolshevism, and at the end of the war arrived in Munich, where he became a contributor to Eckart's little magazine. He had already become an antisemite before 1914, as a result of reading Houston Stewart Chamberlain's work at the age of 16. An enthusiast for the Tsarist police forgery *The Protocols of the Elders of Zion*, which purported to provide evidence of an international Jewish plot to subvert civilization, Rosenberg also read Gobineau and Nietzsche, and after the war wrote polemical tracts attacking Jews and Freemasons. His main desire was to be taken seriously as an intellectual and a cultural theorist. In 1930 Rosenberg was to publish his *magnum opus*, named *The Myth of the Twentieth Century* in homage to the principal work of his idol, Houston Stewart Chamberlain. This was intended to provide the Nazi Party with a major work of theory. The book had sold over a million copies by 1945 and some of its ideas were not without influence. But Hitler himself claimed never to have read more than a small part of it and disliked what he saw as its pseudo-religious tone, and it is unlikely that more than a few of the most dedicated readers managed to plough their way through its acres of turgid prose to the end. Still, in their frequent conversations in Munich cafés, Rosenberg more than anyone probably turned Hitler's attention towards the threat of Communism and its supposed creation by a Jewish conspiracy, and alerted Hitler to what he considered the fragile nature of the Soviet Russian polity. Through Rosenberg, Russian antisemitism, with its extreme conspiracy theories and its exterminatory thrust, found its way into Nazi ideology in the early 1920s. 'Jewish-Bolshevism' now became a major target of Hitler's hate.^{[40](#)}

The other man whom Eckart brought into the Nazi Party was Hans Frank. He was born in Karlsruhe in 1900, the son of a lawyer who initially followed in his father's footsteps. While still a law student, in 1919, he joined the Thule Society and served in the Epp Free Corps in the storming of Munich. Frank quickly fell under Hitler's spell, though he never became one of his inner circle. Hearing him speak in January 1920, Frank felt, like

many others, that Hitler's words came directly from the heart: 'He uttered what was in the consciousness of all those present,' he said later. Throughout his life, he was fascinated by the pornography of violence: he admired brutal men of action, and frequently used the language of violence with a directness and aggression unmatched by almost any other leading Nazi, in an attempt to seem like them; but his legal training and background gave him a residual belief in the law that sometimes sat uneasily alongside his penchant for coarse language and his defence of murderous actions. He qualified as a lawyer, with a doctorate in 1924, and his legal expertise, however limited, was to prove extremely useful to the Party. Up to 1933 he represented it in over 2,400 cases brought against its members, usually for acts of violence of one kind or another. Soon after he defended some Nazi thugs in court for the first time, a senior lawyer who had been one of his teachers said: 'I beg you to leave these people alone! No good will come of it! Political movements that begin in the criminal courts will end in the criminal courts!'^{[41](#)}

By the time these men and many more like them had become part of the Nazi Party, the fledgling movement had an official Programme, composed by Hitler and Drexler with a little help from the 'racial economist' Gottfried Feder, and approved on 24 February 1920. Its 25 points included the demand for 'the union of all Germans in a Greater Germany', the revocation of the 1919 Peace Treaties, 'land and territory (colonies) to feed our people', the prevention of 'non-German immigration', and the death penalty for 'common criminals, usurers, profiteers etc.' Jews were to be denied civil rights and registered as aliens, and they were to be banned from owning or writing for German newspapers. A pseudo-socialist note was sounded by the demand for the abolition of unearned incomes, the confiscation of war profits, the nationalization of business trusts and the introduction of profit-sharing. The Programme concluded with a demand for 'the creation of a strong central state power for the Reich' and the effective replacement of the federated state parliaments by corporations based on estate and occupation'.^{[42](#)} It was a typical far-right document of its time. In practice, it did not mean very much, and, like the Social Democrats' Erfurt Programme of 1891, was often bypassed or ignored in the everyday political struggle, although it was soon declared to be 'unalterable', so as to prevent it from becoming a focus for internal dissension.^{[43](#)}

Richard J. Evans beschreibt den „Beer-Hall Putsch“ im Zusammenhang mit der frühen Entwicklung der NSDAP. Nach dem Ende des Ersten Weltkriegs zog sich Erich Ludendorff zunächst aus der Politik zurück. Er war während der letzten Kriegsjahre einer der mächtigsten Militärs Deutschlands gewesen, wurde jedoch im Oktober 1918 entlassen und floh während der Revolution nach Schweden. Bereits Anfang 1919 kehrte er zurück. Wegen seines Kriegerstatus wurde er schnell zu einer Leitfigur der radikalen Rechten. Er lehnte die Republik und den Versailler Frieden ab und unterstützte Versuche, die neue Ordnung zu stürzen, unter anderem den Kapp-Putsch von 1920. Nach dessen Scheitern ging Ludendorff nach München, wo er in Kontakt mit dem nationalistischen Umfeld um Adolf Hitler kam.

Hitler hatte zu diesem Zeitpunkt bereits erste Anhänger gewonnen, die später für die NSDAP und das „Dritte Reich“ wichtig wurden. Einer von ihnen war Rudolf Heß. Heß suchte nach einer starken Autoritätsfigur, der er sich bedingungslos unterordnen konnte. Er hatte im Krieg gedient, studierte später bei Karl Haushofer in München und bewegte sich in völkischen und rechtsradikalen Kreisen. Sein Antisemitismus war früh ausgeprägt. Er verbreitete antisemitische Flugblätter und sah in Juden angebliche Verräter Deutschlands. In Hitler fand Heß schließlich die Führungsfigur, nach der er gesucht hatte. Seine Verehrung für Hitler war extrem, fast religiös. Zugleich vermittelte Heß Hitler geopolitische Vorstellungen, vor allem die Idee eines deutschen „Lebensraums“ im Osten.

Eine weitere wichtige Figur war Dietrich Eckart. Er war ein gescheiterter Dichter und Dramatiker, der sich in rechtsradikalen und antisemitischen Kreisen bewegte. Sein persönliches Scheitern erklärte er mit angeblichem jüdischem Einfluss auf Kultur und Öffentlichkeit. Eckart hatte Kontakte zu wohlhabenden Unterstützern und zur Armee. Er spielte eine wichtige Rolle beim Erwerb des „Völkischen Beobachters“, der später zum wichtigsten Presseorgan der NSDAP wurde. Als Herausgeber brachte er publizistische Erfahrung in die Partei ein. Später kühlte sein Verhältnis zu Hitler ab, weil Eckart selbstständig blieb und Hitler gegenüber teilweise herablassend auftrat.

Über Eckart gelangten Alfred Rosenberg und Hans Frank in die Nähe der NSDAP. Rosenberg stammte aus dem Baltikum und floh nach der Russischen Revolution nach München. Er entwickelte einen besonders starken Hass auf den Bolschewismus und verband diesen mit antisemitischen Verschwörungsvorstellungen. Er war überzeugt, hinter dem Bolschewismus stehe eine jüdische Weltverschwörung. Durch Rosenberg wurde der Begriff des „jüdischen Bolschewismus“ zu einem zentralen Element der nationalsozialistischen Ideologie. Evans betont, dass Rosenberg Hitlers Aufmerksamkeit besonders auf den Kommunismus und auf die angebliche Schwäche Sowjetrusslands lenkte.

Hans Frank war Jurist und kam ebenfalls früh zur NSDAP. Er bewunderte Hitler und sah in dessen Reden den Ausdruck dessen, was viele Anhänger empfanden. Frank war von Gewalt fasziniert und verwendete selbst eine besonders aggressive Sprache. Gleichzeitig blieb er durch seine juristische Ausbildung mit rechtlichen Formen vertraut. Für die NSDAP wurde er wichtig, weil er zahlreiche Parteimitglieder vor Gericht verteidigte, meist wegen politischer Gewalttaten. Bis 1933 vertrat er die Partei in sehr vielen Verfahren. Evans zeigt damit, dass die frühe NSDAP nicht nur durch Propaganda und Gewalt, sondern auch durch juristische Unterstützung stabilisiert wurde.

Am Ende des Auszugs behandelt Evans das 25-Punkte-Programm der NSDAP, das am 24. Februar 1920 beschlossen wurde. Es wurde von Hitler und Anton Drexler mit Unterstützung Gottfried Feders formuliert. Das Programm forderte unter anderem die Vereinigung aller Deutschen in einem Großdeutschland, die Aufhebung der Friedensverträge von 1919,

Kolonien und zusätzlichen Lebensraum sowie die Begrenzung nichtdeutscher Einwanderung. Juden sollten staatsbürgerliche Rechte verweigert werden; sie sollten als Fremde gelten und keinen Einfluss auf deutsche Zeitungen haben.

Daneben enthielt das Programm scheinbar soziale Forderungen. Dazu gehörten die Abschaffung arbeitsloser Einkommen, die Einziehung von Kriegsgewinnen, die Verstaatlichung großer Unternehmen und Gewinnbeteiligung. Evans macht jedoch deutlich, dass diese Forderungen nicht bedeuteten, dass die NSDAP eine sozialistische Partei war. Vielmehr handelte es sich um ein typisches rechtsextremes Programm der Zeit, das Nationalismus, Antisemitismus, Autoritarismus und soziale Parolen miteinander verband. Im politischen Alltag spielte das Programm nur begrenzt eine verbindliche Rolle. Wichtiger waren Führerkult, Gewaltbereitschaft, Propaganda und die ideologische Feindbildkonstruktion.

Insgesamt zeigt Evans, dass die frühe NSDAP aus einem breiteren völkischen, antisemitischen und antirepublikanischen Milieu hervorging. Hitler konnte sich in diesem Umfeld durch seine Reden, seine Fähigkeit zur Mobilisierung und seinen Anspruch auf Führung durchsetzen. Die Partei gewann Unterstützung durch ehemalige Militärs, völkische Intellektuelle, antisemitische Publizisten, Juristen und gewaltbereite Aktivisten. Ihre frühe Entwicklung war geprägt durch Hass auf die Weimarer Republik, Ablehnung des Versailler Vertrags, Antisemitismus, Antibolschewismus, Führerglauben und politische Gewalt.

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